

SCORE
BOARD **The Multimedia Packages**

	Adobe LiveMotion 1.0.2	Formula Graphic 97 Multimedia System	Illuminatus Opus	Macromedia Authorware 5.2	Macromedia Director 8.5 Shockwave Studio	Macromedia Flash 5
Company	Adobe Systems India, 0118-4532026, sandeep@adobe.com	www.formulagraphics.com Free for download	www.digitalworkshop.com	Wipro Infotech, 080-8440011, surajs@wipro.co.in	Wipro Infotech, 080-8440011, surajs@wipro.co.in	Wipro Infotech, 080-8440011, surajs@wipro.co.in
Price	Rs 17,765	2.9	Rs 5,870(approx)	Rs 1,16,000	Rs 47,950	Rs 19,000
Space required	100		50	60	100	40
File Format Supported						
(a) Images	JPEG, GIF, Animated GIF, TIFF, BMPEPS, PSD, targa, pixar etc.	JPEG, GIF, Animated GIF, BMP, PSD, PNG, VEC, 3DS, etc.	JPEG, GIF,BMP, PNG, TIFF, WMF Etc.	JPEG, bitmap, GIF, PSD, TIFF, Animated GIF, PNG, etc	JPEG, bitmap, GIF, PSD, TIFF, Animated GIF, PNG, Shockwave 3D, etc	JPEG, GIF, BMP, PNG, TIFF, WMF, EPS, AI, FH, etc
(b) Sound	WAV	Wav	MP3, Wav, Midi etc.	Wav	AVI, MOV, Real Media, etc	MP3, Wav,AIF, MOV, AVI
(c) Video	Can't import	AVI, MOV	MPEG. AVI, MOV, etc	MPEG, AVI, MOV		
Transition Effects	No predefined effects	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes but no pre-defined
Animation	Path based animation not posible	Custom animation not possible	Custom animation possible	No, only importing of animation possible	Path based animation not possible	Path based animation possible
Masking Capabilities	Yes	No	No	No	Yes, through Lingo	Yes
Creation of Buttons	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Drawing Tools	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Projector Creation	No	No	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Rating	B+	B-	B	B	A-	B+

Formula Graphic 97 disappoints when it comes to integrated help—it just provides extremely elementary help, making it difficult for new users to learn and use advanced features of the software. Adobe's LiveMotion, on the other hand, provides satisfactory help to users by explaining how to work around with the software.

CONCLUSION

Professional-level multimedia authoring software costs quite a bit, so if you are only interested in creating basic, uncomplicated projects, it doesn't make sense purchas-

ing a high-end utility. Also, you need some basic skills to work efficiently with some of these packages. For instance, going in for Director without learning Lingo wouldn't make much sense.

Furthermore, some of these packages are better suited for certain kinds of projects. For instance, trainers, developers, instructional designers and tutors who need to create visually rich media for online learning applications can primarily use Authorware, while software such as Illuminatus Opus and Formula Graphic 97 Multimedia System weren't that much up to the mark. However, if you are just starting off on multimedia authoring, Illuminatus Opus is a good enough tool to start off with.

As far as Web animation is concerned, Flash and LiveMotion are basically targeted at a similar set of users who do a lot of animation. Their prices are almost the same, but Flash

scores higher due to the features that it presents, as also the layer-based animation in Flash that is much easier to use than the object-based animation of LiveMotion. Flash also has more pre-defined scripts.

For professionals who make projects not for internal purposes but also for corporate clients, the advanced features provided by Director would be quite valuable.

With Director, you can import almost all known file formats generally used in the industry. Plus it adds support for sound channels and has robust scripting capabilities.

With **Director 8.5**, you also have support for 3D objects. Overall, the feature-set, online help, animation and file import capabilities, along with a very easy-to-navigate interface make it the best multimedia authoring applications to work with.■



Flash 5 provides support for XML



Director: the winning choice